PREMIER LEAGUE

Seven Stats to Show Just How Mad the Premier League 2025-26 Has Been

DEC 26, 2025 | ALI TWEEDALE / AUTHOR, MATT SIGNEROS / DESIGN

The Premier League season is 17 matchdays old, and it's been eventful, to say the least. Here are seven stats to show just how extraordinary 2025-26 has been.

The 2025-26 season has been crazy.

Following Fulham's win over Nottingham Forest on Monday night, every team have played 17 games, and there is an awful lot to unpack just from looking at the Premier League table.

Delve a little deeper, too, and there's even more reason to be surprised by what we've seen so far.

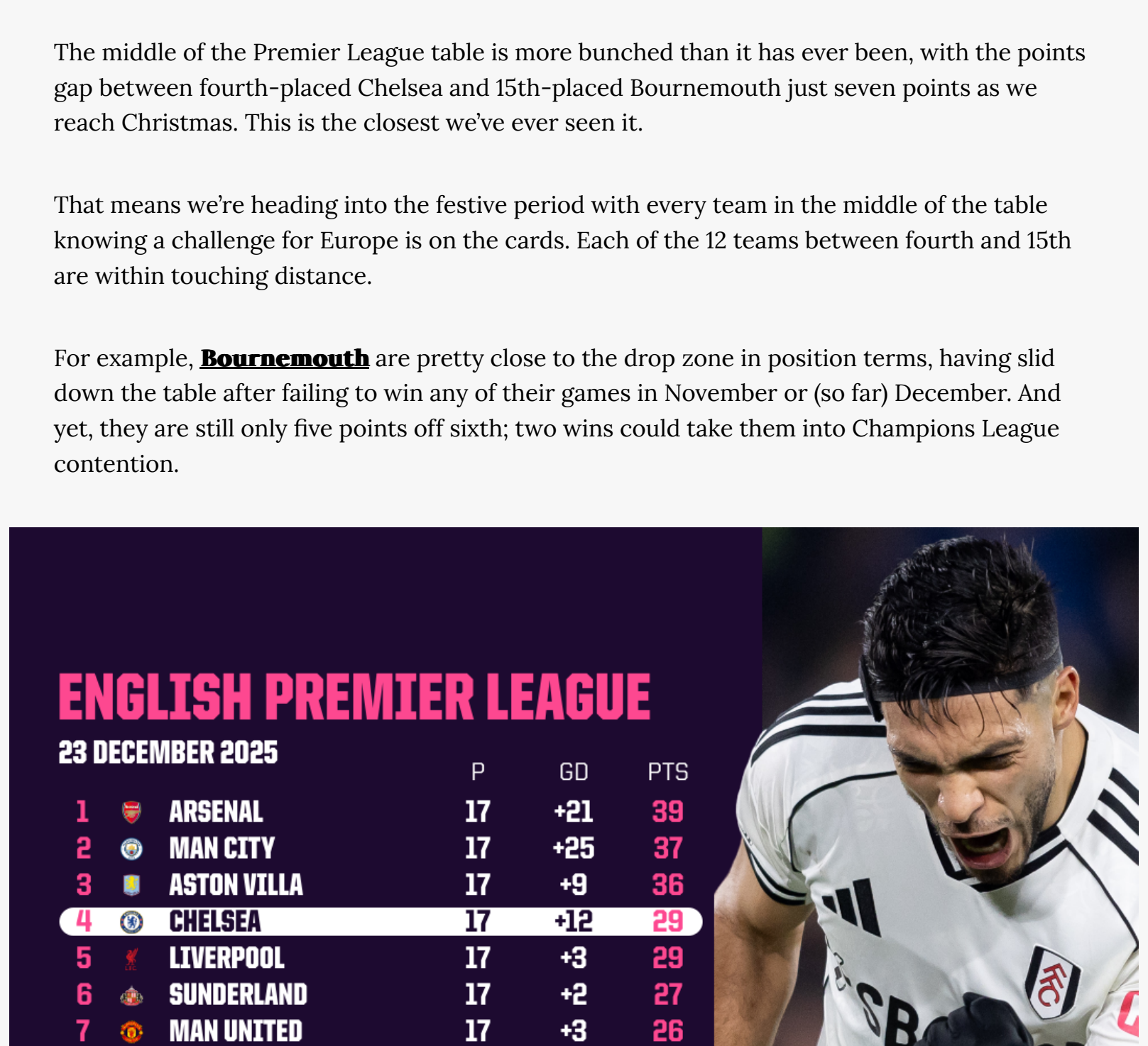
With Christmas upon us, we've decided to take a closer look at the numbers. Here are seven ways in which 2025-26 has been utterly wild.

The European Hunt Is Closer Than Ever

The middle of the Premier League table is more bunched than it has ever been, with the points gap between fourth-placed Chelsea and 15th-placed Bournemouth just seven points as we reach Christmas. This is the closest we've ever seen.

That means we're heading into the festive period with every team in the middle of the table knowing a challenge for Europe is on the cards. Each of the 12 teams between fourth and 15th are within touching distance.

For example, **Bournemouth** are pretty close to the drop zone in position terms, having slid down the table after failing to win any of their games in November or (so far) December. And yet, they are still only five points off sixth; two wins could take them into Champions League contention.



ENGLISH PREMIER LEAGUE
23 DECEMBER 2025

		P	GD	PTS
1	ARSENAL	17	+21	39
2	MAN CITY	17	+25	37
3	ASTON VILLA	17	+9	36
4	CHELSEA	17	+12	29
5	LIVERPOOL	17	+3	29
6	SUNDERLAND	17	+2	27
7	MAN UNITED	17	+3	26
8	CRYSTAL PALACE	17	+2	26
9	BRIGHTON	17	+2	24
10	EVERTON	17	-2	24
11	NEWCASTLE UNITED	17	+1	23
12	BRENTFORD	17	-1	23
13	FULHAM	17	-2	23
14	SPURS	17	+3	22
15	BOURNEMOUTH	17	-3	22
16	LEEDS UNITED	17	-7	19
17	NOTT'M FOREST	17	-9	18
18	WEST HAM	17	-16	13
19	BURNLEY	17	-15	11
20	WOLVES	17	-28	2

Similarly, Tottenham are enduring one of their worst seasons in recent memory, but they are still 14th despite a run of one win in eight. Now, without a game against any team who finished in last season's top eight until February, they will continue to hold out hope that a couple of good results could completely turn their season around.

It's the same for every team in that bunch. Brentford beat Wolves at the weekend for their first win in four and all of a sudden are one win off the European places. Manchester United are three points off the Champions League places despite having had a mixed season. Liverpool are fifth despite enduring a four-game losing run – only Burnley and Wolves have had longer. Fulham's win on Monday night has taken them to just a point off the top half. Weren't they in a relegation battle five minutes ago? The Premier League table is more forgiving than ever before.

Nottingham Forest in 17th and Leeds in 16th will probably still be concentrating on making sure they can stay clear of relegation trouble, but given they have both been on decent runs recently, they have as much reason to look up as down. Leeds are closer to the top half of the table than they are the relegation zone.

It all means the battle for European football is tighter than ever before, but also, relegation isn't much of a concern…

The Relegation Battle Could Be Over, but Not How Everyone Expected

For two seasons in a row, all three promoted teams were relegated from the Premier League, so there was reasonable concern heading into 2025-26 that it would happen again. It looked very much like the gap between the top flight and the Championship was getting too big for promoted clubs to bridge. The worry was the relegation battle would be over by Christmas.

The bad news is it looks like it might be over already, but the good news for those looking for competitiveness in the Premier League is that only one promoted team look doomed. It's not quite everyone's worst fear being realised, with the Premier League cutting itself loose from the rest of the footballing pyramid, but for anyone looking for some excitement at the bottom of the table, it's not looking great.

The gap between 17th and 18th – the positions between safety and relegation – is five points, the joint biggest it's ever been at this stage of a Premier League season. And the only other season that also had a five-point gap was two years ago, in 2023-24, when the promoted sides struggled terribly and all went straight back down. That year, the bottom three barely gave any sign they could catch the rest of the league and make the relegation battle interesting. They were cut adrift by the 17-game mark and never recovered.

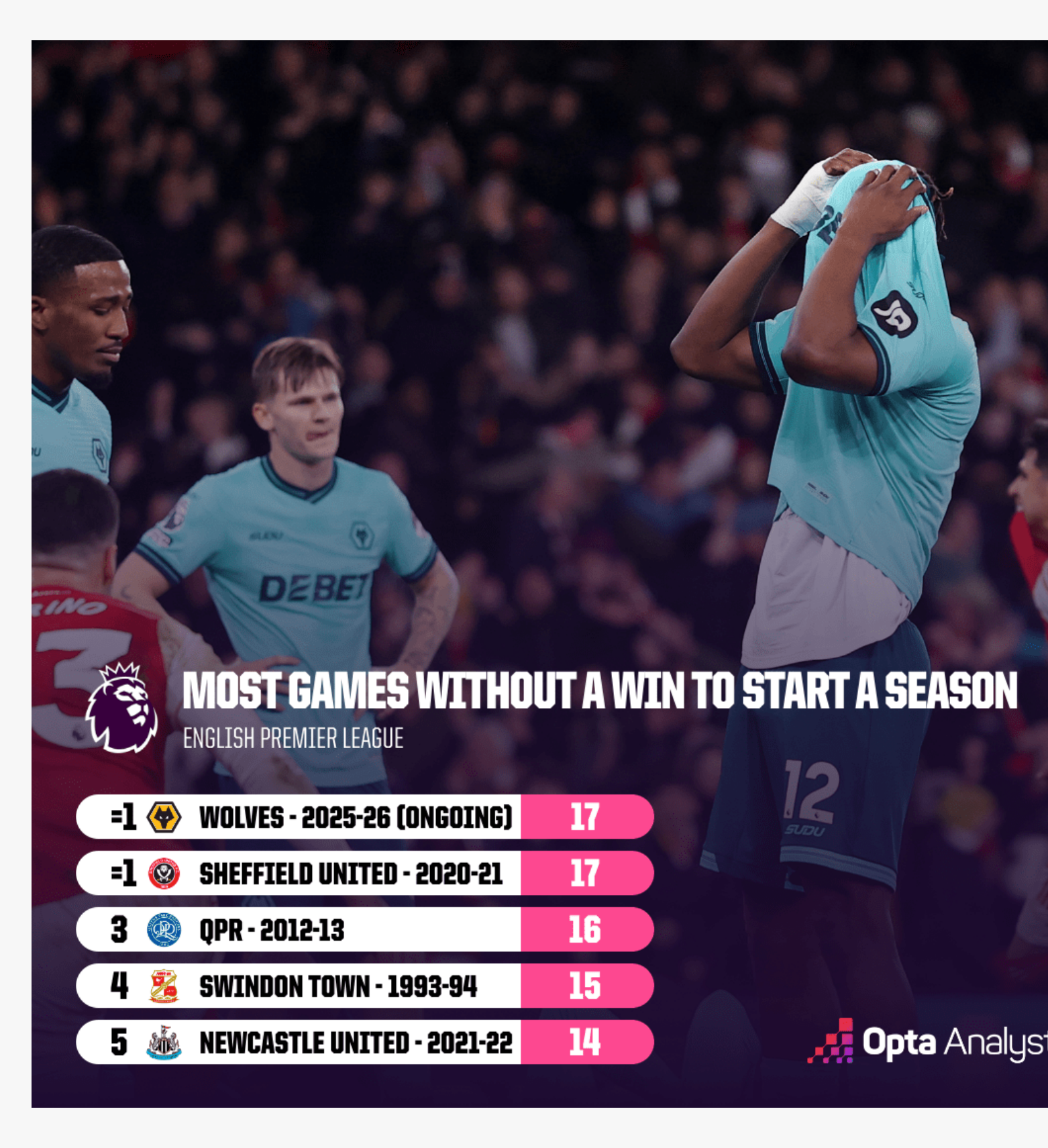
This time around, the gap is just as extreme, with **West Ham**, **Burnley** and Wolves having won just six out of 51 games between them. Forest, Leeds and Fulham are pulling clear, too. We'll need a miracle to get a relegation battle this season.

Wolves Could Obliterate Derby's Record

Talking of the lack of a relegation battle, **Wolves** are very much to blame. Unless something drastic changes, we could be about to witness a historically bad season.

At the weekend, they **equalled the Premier League record for the longest winless start to a season**, but there's more. Much, much more.

No side in the history of the top four divisions of men's English football have ever got fewer points from their first 17 games of a season than the two Wolves have (also Newport County in the fourth tier in 1970-71 and Sheffield United in the Premier League in 2020-21). They have lost their last 11 games, becoming only the fourth side in Premier League history to reach double figures for successive defeats. They've only scored nine goals. Nine!



MOST GAMES WITHOUT A WIN TO START A SEASON
ENGLISH PREMIER LEAGUE

=1	WOLVES - 2025-26 (ONGOING)	17
=1	SHEFFIELD UNITED - 2020-21	17
3	QPR - 2012-13	16
4	SWINDON TOWN - 1993-94	15
5	NEWCASTLE UNITED - 2021-22	14

Opta Analyst

Everything about this season has been utterly dismal, and with each passing week, things look less and less likely to change.

Relegation is surely a certainty now, even for the team who enjoyed such a dramatic turnaround in their fortunes after changing manager last season. Vitor Pereira took over when they had nine points from 16 matches last term and were second-bottom, and they recovered brilliantly to finish well clear of the drop zone.

But this season is a whole different kettle of fish.

The aim, much like Southampton last season, has to be to avoid becoming the worst team in Premier League history. Derby County's famous total of 11 points from 2007-08 looks terribly far away right now.

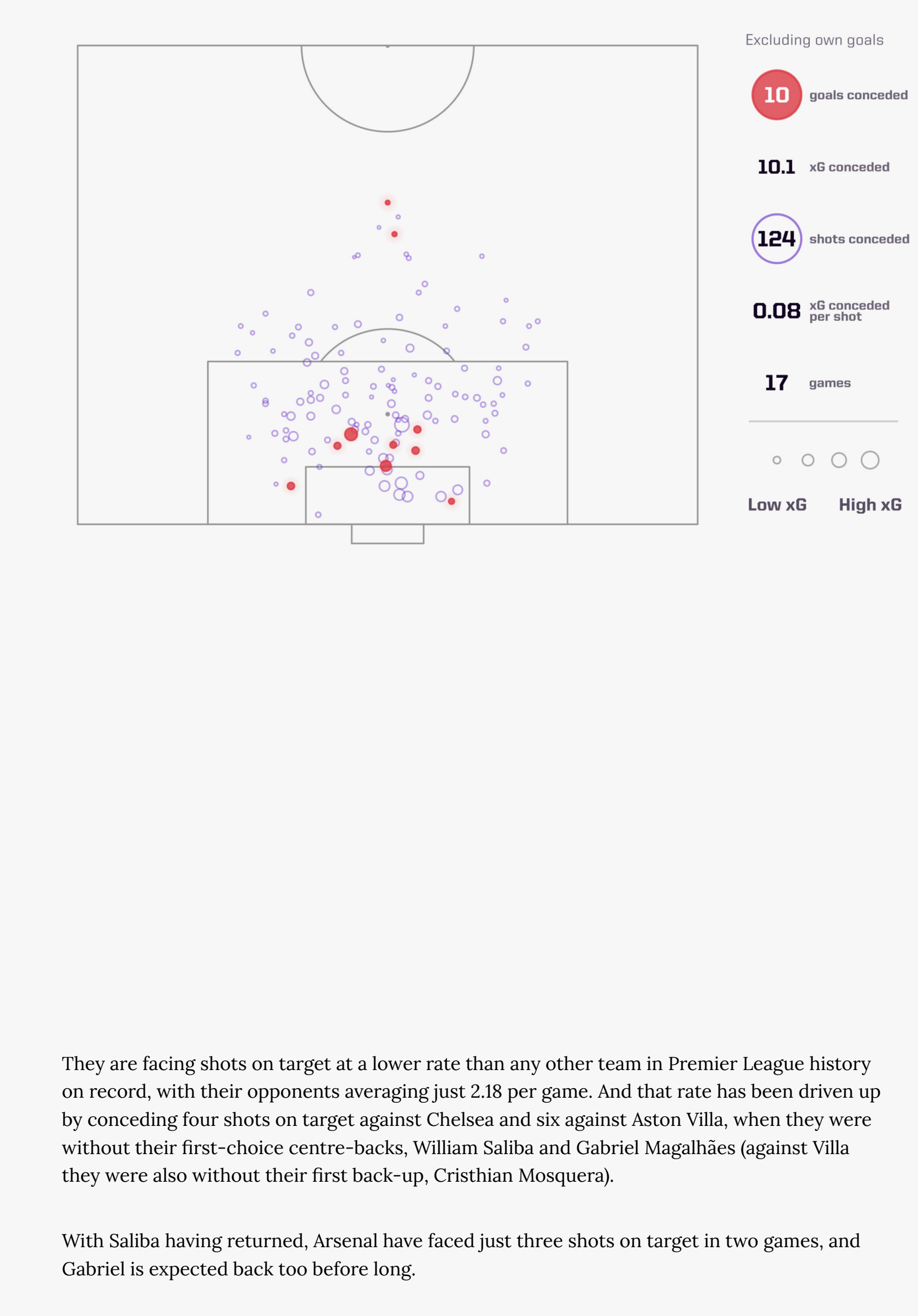
The longer this winless run goes on, the more hopeless Wolves appear, and hauling themselves up to five points, let alone 10, looks like it will be a big ask. Is Derby's record about to be smashed?

Raya Is the Least Busy Goalkeeper in Premier League History

Even in the face of a defensive injury crisis that left them without any of their best three centre-backs for a period, **Arsenal** have been astoundingly resilient this season.

Their quest to break **Chelsea**'s record for the fewest goals conceded by any team in Premier League history (15 in 2004-05) might well be over following a run of conceding seven goals in six games (after shipping just three in their first 10), but they might break a record for needing a goalkeeper less than any other team.

Obviously **David Raya** is a very important part of this ludicrously watertight defence, but arguably the most impressive aspect of Arsenal's defensive record is how infrequently their goalkeeper is exposed.



They are facing shots on target at a lower rate than any other team in Premier League history on record, with their opponents averaging just 2.18 per game. And that rate has been driven up by conceding four shots on target against Chelsea and six against Aston Villa, when they were without their first-choice centre-backs, William Saliba and Gabriel Magalhães (against Villa they were also without their first back-up, Cristhian Mosquera).

With Saliba having returned, Arsenal have faced just three shots on target in two games, and Gabriel is expected back too before long.

If Arsenal can shake off **their recent mini-wobble** and get back to their defensive best, Raya could put his feet up.

Haaland Could Break 40 Goals

Hearing that **Erling Haaland** could break another goalscoring record will hardly come as a surprise. He's put his name next to so many Premier League records since joining **Manchester City** that it feels inevitable he will eventually break all of them.

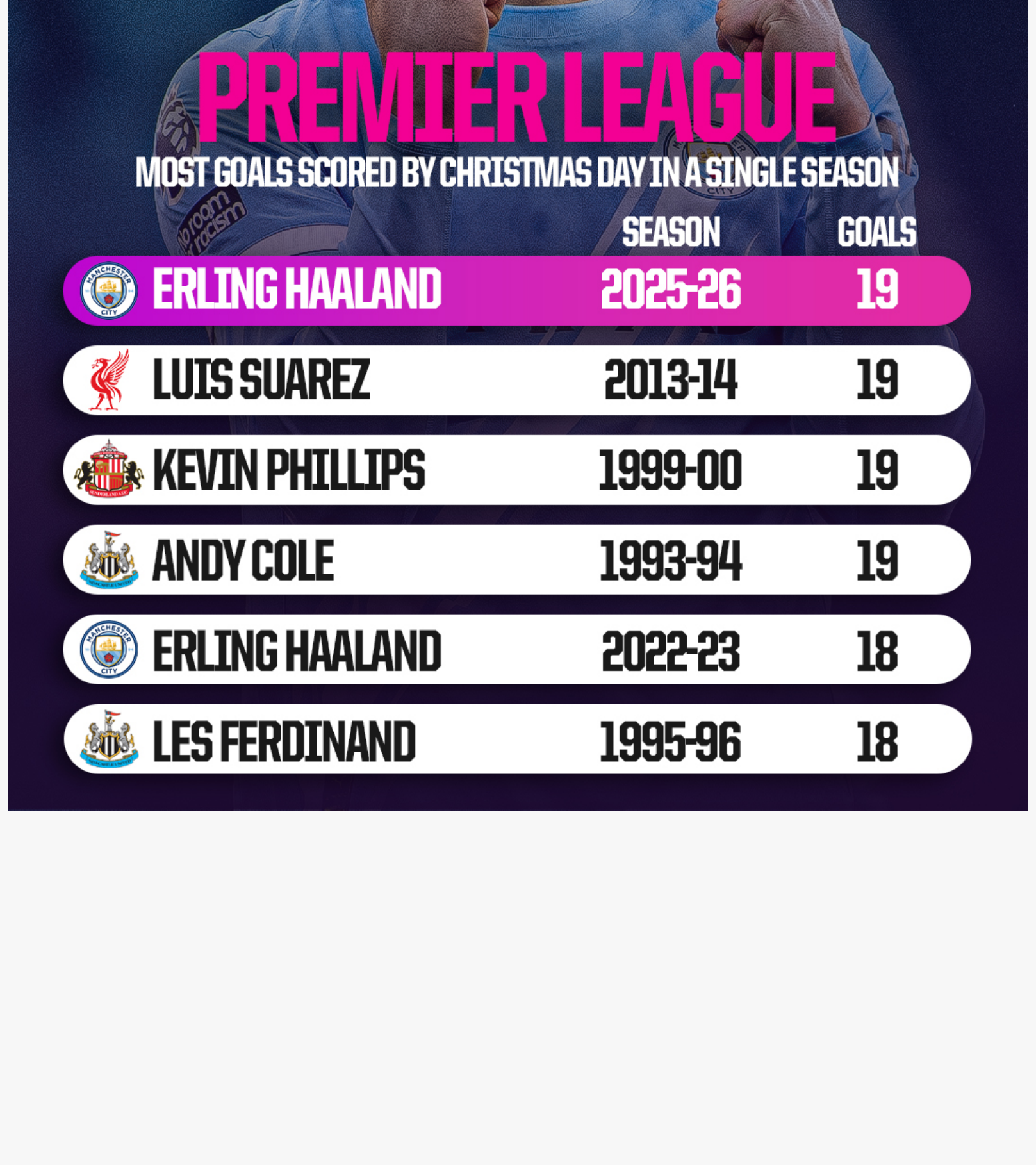
But even for him, a 40-goal season had appeared a step too far. Until now.

He broke the record for goals in a season in his first campaign in England, scoring 36 times to take an accolade that had been shared by Alan Shearer and Andrew Cole for nearly three decades.

Now, *his* previous record appears surmountable.

That's because Haaland has 19 goals in 17 appearances already this season. After a minor blip when he scored just one goal in four games, he looks back to his ruthless, efficient best, having struck back-to-back braces against Crystal Palace and West Ham. In the latter of those games, he very, very nearly completed his first City hat-trick of the season, only to miss a late one-on-one by a matter of inches.

He is only the fourth player to reach 19 goals before Christmas, after Luis Suárez in 2013-14, Kevin Phillips in 1999-2000 and Cole in 1993-94. Each of those three players kept on scoring but their goals rate slowed slightly after 25 December, with Suárez reaching 31 goals by the end of the season, Phillips 30 and Cole 34.



PREMIER LEAGUE
MOST GOALS SCORED BY CHRISTMAS DAY IN A SINGLE SEASON

	SEASON	GOALS
ERLING HAALAND	2025-26	19
LUIS SUAREZ	2013-14	19
KEVIN PHILLIPS	1999-00	19
ANDY COLE	1993-94	19
ERLING HAALAND	2022-23	18
LES FERDINAND	1995-96	18

Playing for Pep Guardiola's City, who have the bit between their teeth as they aim to chase Arsenal down at the top of the table (again), is surely a more reliable environment to maintain such an impressive scoring rate than Brendan Rodgers' Liverpool, Sunderland at the turn of the century or Newcastle in the early 1990s.

Haaland *has* outscored his xG, but he's not *relying* on his exceptional finishing; he has had chances worth 16.1 xG, which is more than Sunderland, Wolves or Burnley have had in total, and nearly as much as Spurs, too (16.4 xG). He is averaging 0.99 xG per 90, so if he stays fit for the rest of the season, he might well have enough chances to keep on scoring at his current rate.

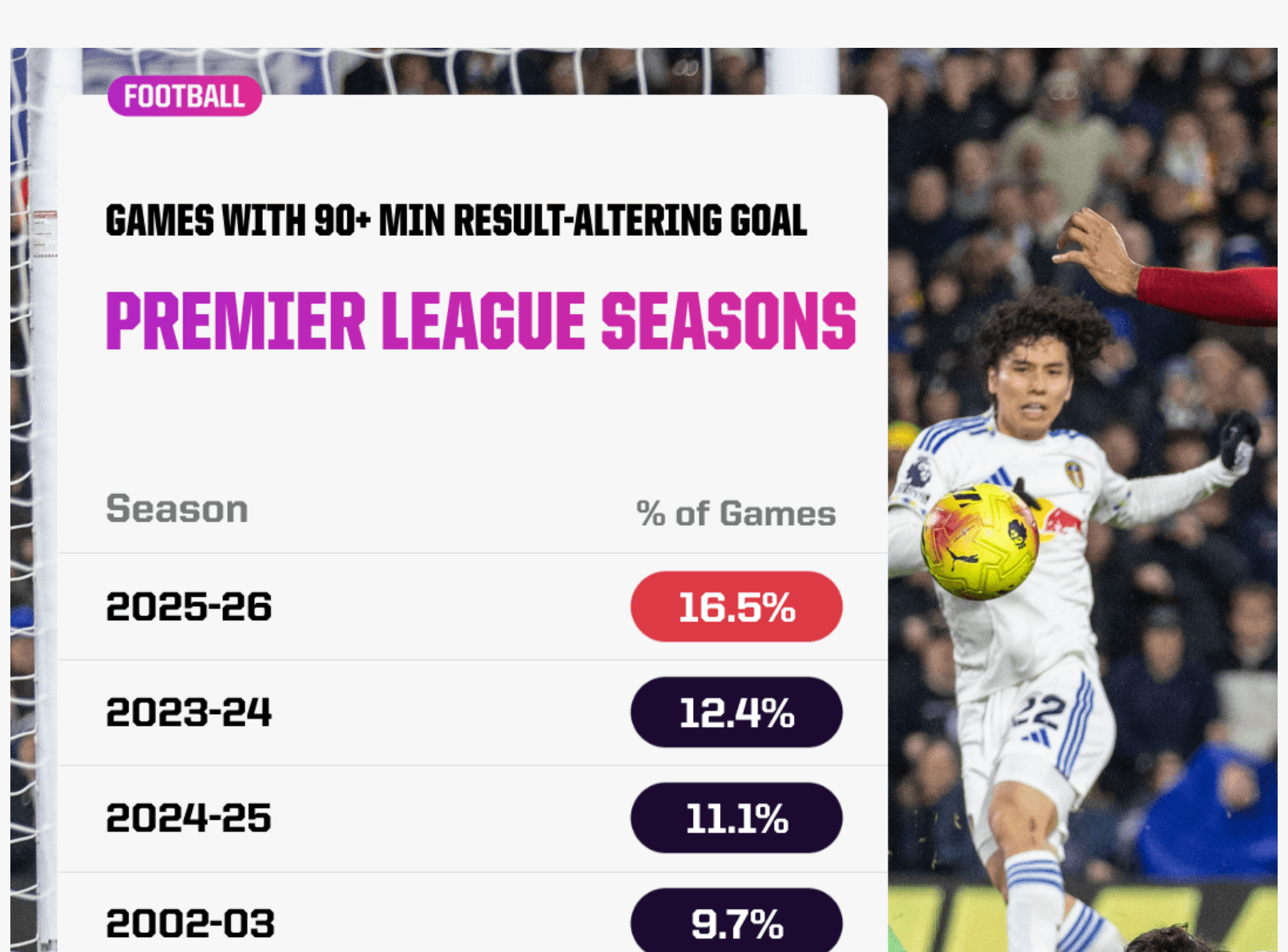
City are creating tonnes for him, and it just doesn't look like there's any stopping him. He has moved the goalposts (ahem) when it comes to goalscoring, and he has set himself up to do something even more remarkable this season.

The Premier League Has Gone Late-Goal Crazy

We've all seen the fourth official boards with double figures on there. We all know games are longer these days. It stands to reason that there'd be more late drama as a result.

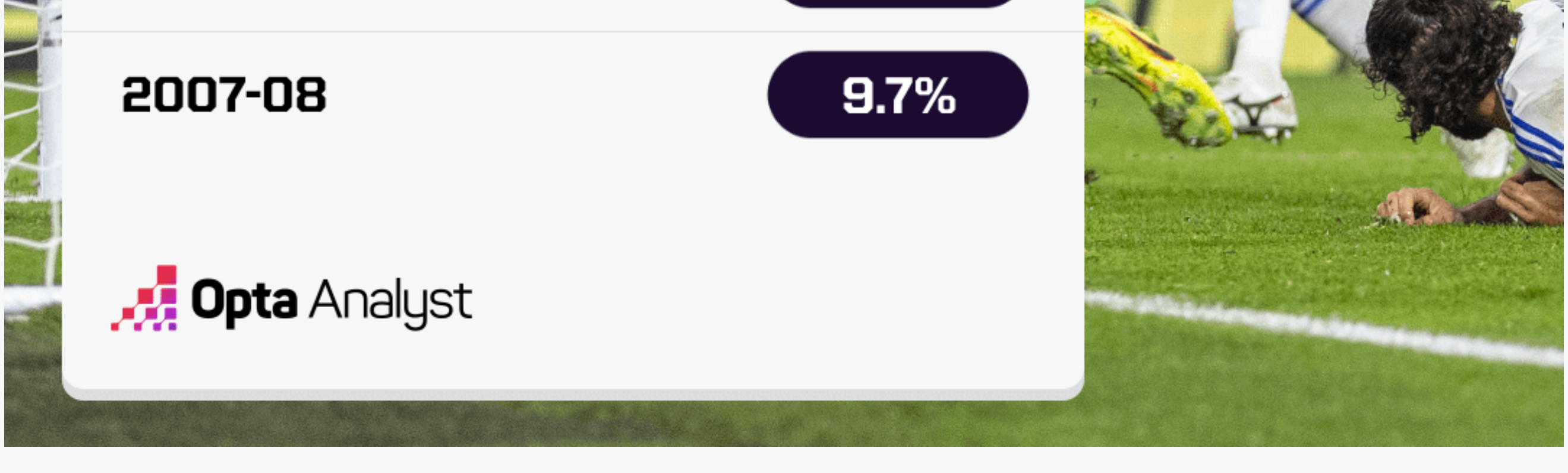
But this season it has been even more remarkable than in previous years.

In 2025-26, 16.5% of all games have seen a result-altering goal scored in second-half stoppage time. The previous highest was 12.4% in 2023-24. Over the course of the entire Premier League era, just 6.7% of games have produced a 90th-minute goal that changed the result of the match.



FOOTBALL
GAMES WITH 90+ MIN RESULT-ALTERING GOAL
PREMIER LEAGUE SEASONS

Season	% of Games
2025-26	16.5%
2023-24	12.4%
2024-25	11.1%
2002-03	9.7%



It's not really fair to compare this season to 20 or 30 years ago. There have been 28 result-altering late goals already this season, when there were just nine in the whole of 2000-01. It was a completely different game then.

But even compared to the last few seasons, for which stoppage time was also vastly increased, this season is extreme.

The proportion means that on average, each 10-game matchday is seeing 1.6 result-altering stoppage-time goals. So, what that actually means is, every week there is one, but more often there are two.

If we just look at stoppage-time winners, there are also more than ever before, with 9.4% of games seeing one – or almost one every matchday – which is a huge increase from 5.8% last season and the previous high of 7.1% the season before.

Late drama has been a consistent and prominent theme of this season.

Long-Range Bangers Are Back

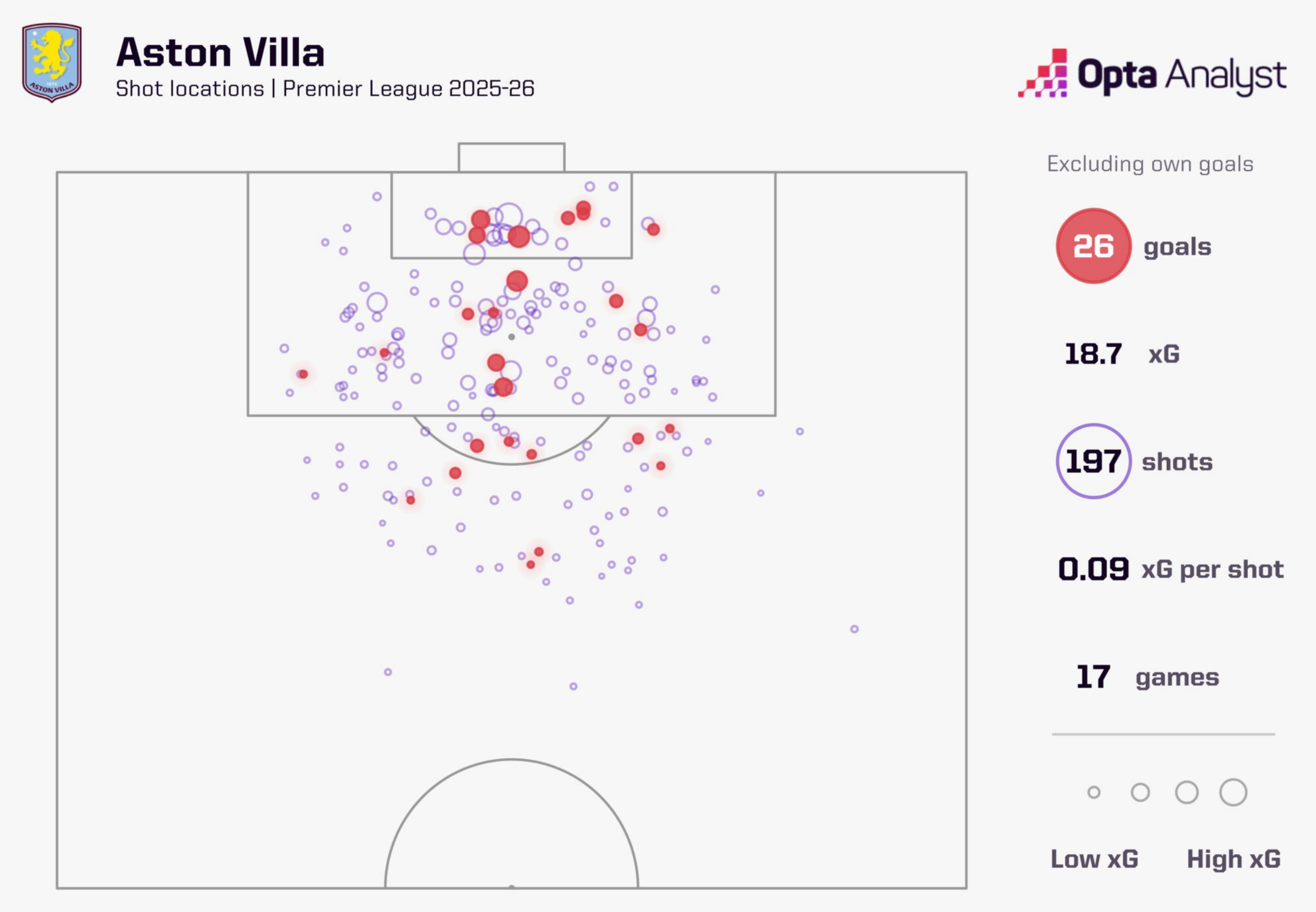
As well as late drama, there have been more eye-catching moments than any other recent season, with 14.8% of all goals scored from outside the penalty area, at a rate of or 0.42 per game. Both are the highest such rates in over a decade, since 2013-14 which, entirely incidentally, was Steven Gerrard's penultimate season playing in England.

Football these days is so data-driven that teams are obsessed with getting high-xG chances; opportunities they are more likely to score. It's at least part of the reason that the number of long-distance shots in the Premier League has consistently been going down for years. Everyone is working out how much less likely they are to result in a goal, so they are attempting them less. It makes sense.

And this season is the same: with an average of 7.8 shots from outside the box per game, shots from range are being attempted at their lowest rate on record (since 2003-04) in the Premier League era.

But this season, they are being converted so efficiently that we are seeing a sharp rise in goals from distance. Shots from outside the penalty area this season are going in 5.4% of the time, which is the highest rate on record in the Premier League, significantly ahead of the second-highest seasonal rate of 4.5% in 2022-23.

Is this just variance, or has the unquestionable increase in quality of Premier League footballers led us to a point at which players can pick their spot from distance better than ever before? It could be either of those, but for now, it looks like there is more value in shooting from distance than in the past. **Aston Villa are third in the table**, having scored more goals from outside the box than any other team this season (10), and they could challenge the Premier League record of 23, by Chelsea in 2006-07.



The next question will be whether teams now start shooting from distance *more* often, because their players are so good at it.

The rest of the season will give us a better indication as to whether or not this is a sign of things to come.

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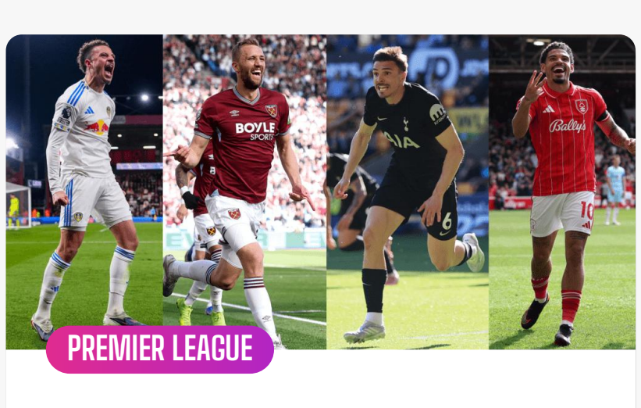
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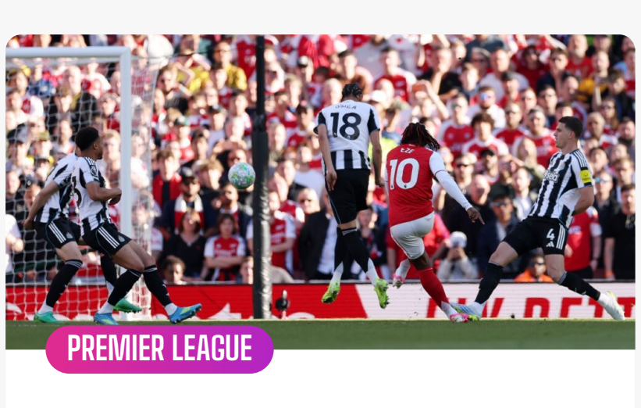
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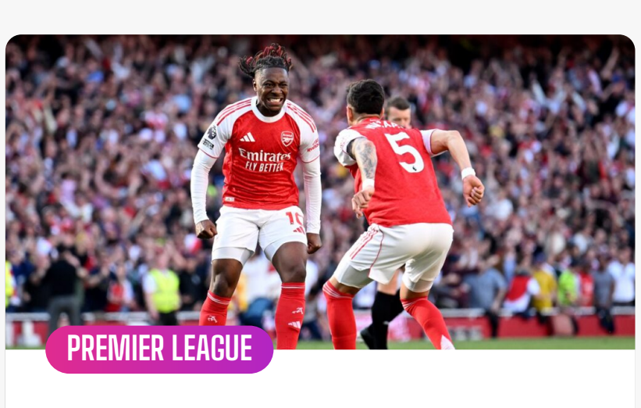
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